Nazism and the Rise of Hitler

The big idea

In the 1930s Germany fell under the control of **Adolf Hitler** and his **Nazi** party, who destroyed democracy, glorified war and carried out the **Holocaust**, the murder of about six million Jews. This chapter explains how a democratic republic collapsed into dictatorship and what the Nazis believed.

KEY DATES

1918 Germany defeated in WWI; Weimar Republic formed · **1919** Treaty of Versailles · **1923** hyperinflation · **1929** Great Depression · **30 Jan 1933** Hitler becomes Chancellor · **28 Feb 1933** Fire Decree · **3 Mar 1933** Enabling Act · **1939** Germany invades Poland; WWII begins · **1941** Germany attacks USSR; USA joins war after Pearl Harbor · **May 1945** Germany surrenders; **Aug 1945** atomic bombs on Hiroshima and Nagasaki.

Birth of the Weimar Republic

Germany fought the First World War (1914–18) alongside Austria against the **Allies** (England, France, Russia). Defeated, the emperor abdicated and a National Assembly met at **Weimar** to set up a democratic, federal constitution. Deputies were elected with equal and universal votes, including women.

Problems of the Republic:

- The **Treaty of Versailles (1919)** was harsh: Germany lost its overseas colonies, **13% of its territory**, 75% of its iron and 26% of its coal; it had to demilitarise and pay **war compensation of £6 billion**. The Allies occupied the resource-rich **Rhineland**. Many Germans blamed the Republic and called its supporters the "**November criminals**".

- **Political radicalism:** the **Spartacist League**, a Bolshevik-style uprising, was crushed by the Republic with the help of the **Free Corps**.
- **Hyperinflation (1923):** when Germany could not pay, France occupied the **Ruhr** (its coal area). Germany printed paper money recklessly; the mark collapsed (a dollar cost 4 trillion marks). The USA rescued Germany with the **Dawes Plan**.
- **Great Depression (1929):** after the **Wall Street crash** American loans were withdrawn. By 1932 German industrial production fell to 40% of 1929 levels, and about **6 million** were unemployed.
- **Weak constitution: proportional representation** made it nearly impossible for one party to win a majority, leading to coalitions. **Article 48** let the President impose emergency, suspend civil rights and rule by decree. People lost faith in democracy.

Hitler's rise to power

Hitler, born in Austria in 1889, joined the **German Workers' Party**, renamed it the **National Socialist German Workers' Party (Nazi Party)**. In 1923 he tried to seize Bavaria and capture Berlin but failed. During the Depression Nazism became a mass movement: in **1932** the Nazis got **37%** of the vote and became the largest party.

Why people supported him: he was a powerful speaker, promised to build a strong nation, undo Versailles, restore dignity, give jobs and a secure future to the young. The Nazis used **propaganda**: massive rallies, red banners with the **swastika**, the Nazi salute, and Hitler projected as a saviour.

Destruction of democracy:

- **30 January 1933**: President **Hindenburg** offered Hitler the Chancellorship.
- **Fire Decree (28 February 1933)**: after a mysterious fire in the parliament building (Reichstag), civic rights such as freedom of speech, press and assembly were suspended indefinitely.
- Communists were hurriedly packed off to **concentration camps**.

- **Enabling Act (3 March 1933)**: established dictatorship; Hitler could bypass parliament and rule by decree. All parties except the Nazi party were banned; trade unions too.
- Special forces: **SA (Storm Troopers)**, **Gestapo** (secret state police), **SS** (protection squads), criminal police and the Security Service.

Economy and foreign policy: Hjalmar Schacht aimed at full production and employment through state-funded work projects (the famous **Volkswagen** and **autobahns**). Germany pulled out of the **League of Nations** (1933), reoccupied the Rhineland (1936), integrated Austria (1938) under the slogan "**One people, One empire, One leader**", and took the German-speaking Sudetenland of Czechoslovakia. In **September 1939** Germany invaded **Poland**, starting the Second World War. In 1940 a **Tripartite Pact** was signed between Germany, Italy and Japan. Hitler's attack on the **USSR in 1941** was a historic blunder; the defeat at **Stalingrad** turned the tide. After Japan bombed **Pearl Harbor**, the USA entered the war. It ended in **May 1945** with Hitler's defeat and the US atomic bombs on Japan in August.

The Nazi worldview

- **No equality**: there was a **racial hierarchy**. **Nordic German Aryans** were at the top; **Jews** were at the bottom, seen as an "anti-race". Blacks, Russians and Poles also lay low.
- Borrowed from **Charles Darwin** and **Herbert Spencer** ("survival of the fittest"), twisted to justify that the strongest race survives.
- **Lebensraum** (living space): acquire new territories for settlement, especially in the East (Poland).
- Only "pure and healthy Nordic Aryans" were desirable. Others, even Germans seen as impure or abnormal, were killed under the **Euthanasia Programme**; Gypsies and Blacks were persecuted.

The Holocaust: Jews were excluded step by step: the **Nuremberg Laws (1935)** took away citizenship and banned marriages between Jews and Germans; the

Kristallnacht ("night of broken glass", November 1938) saw synagogues and shops attacked; Jews were moved to **ghettos** and then to gas chambers in camps such as **Auschwitz**. About six million Jews were killed. The Nazis used **euphemisms**: "**Final Solution**" for genocide, "**special treatment**" and "**evacuation**" for killing and deportation, "**disinfection areas**" for gas chambers.

Youth and women in Nazi Germany

Youth: schools were "cleansed" of Jewish and "politically unreliable" teachers; textbooks rewritten. At **10**, boys entered **Jungvolk**; at **14**, the **Hitler Youth**; at 18, the Labour Service, then the armed forces. They were taught to hate Jews, communists and Gypsies and to worship war.

Women: boys were taught to be aggressive; girls were told to be good mothers and rear **pure-blooded Aryan children**. Women who bore racially desirable children were rewarded with privileges and the **Honour Cross** (bronze for four children, silver for six, gold for eight or more). Women who married Jews or other "undesirables" were publicly punished.

NAZISM IS NOT JUST "DICTATORSHIP"

The key exam word is **racism**. The Nazi state was built on a racial hierarchy and the idea of Lebensraum. Mention both in any "Nazi ideology" answer.

BOARD FAVOURITE

"Why did Nazism become popular in Germany by 1930?" Combine: Versailles humiliation, economic crises (1923 and 1929), weak Weimar constitution (proportional representation, Article 48), Hitler's oratory and propaganda.

Quick recap

- Weimar Republic burdened by Versailles, hyperinflation and the Depression; Article 48 and proportional representation weakened it.
- Hitler became Chancellor in 1933; Fire Decree and Enabling Act ended democracy.
- Nazi ideology: racial hierarchy, Lebensraum, hatred of Jews → Holocaust.
- Children were trained through Jungvolk and Hitler Youth; women were valued as mothers of Aryan children.
- WWII: 1939 (Poland) to 1945.

Practice questions

1. The National Assembly that created Germany's democratic constitution after WWI met at
   (a) Berlin (b) Weimar (c) Versailles (d) Munich
2. Which article of the Weimar constitution allowed the President to rule by decree?
   (a) Article 21 (b) Article 32 (c) Article 356 (d) Article 48
3. The Enabling Act of March 1933
   (a) established dictatorship by giving Hitler power to bypass parliament (b) gave women the right to vote (c) ended the Second World War (d) created the Weimar Republic
4. "Lebensraum" in Nazi ideology means
   (a) racial purity (b) the Final Solution (c) living space (d) the Nazi salute
5. At what age did boys in Nazi Germany join the Hitler Youth?
   (a) 10 (b) 18 (c) 21 (d) 14
6. The French occupation of which German industrial area in 1923 led to hyperinflation?
   (a) Rhineland (b) Ruhr (c) Bavaria (d) Sudetenland
7. Which of these was a Nazi euphemism for genocide?
   (a) Lebensraum (b) Enabling Act (c) Final Solution (d) Honour Cross
8. Discuss why Nazism became popular in Germany by 1930.
9. What was the role of women in Nazi Germany?

Answers: 1. b 2. d 3. a 4. c 5. d 6. b 7. c 8. see notes 9. see notes